

Workshop Session 1 | Unlocking the potential of SDG interactions

Discussion Paper

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The aim of this paper is to provide preparatory background material as well as initial ideas and guidance for workshop discussions on unlocking the potential of SDG interactions for the oceans. It presents initial thinking on how to better address the interconnected of the SDGs in the follow-up and review process and, yet, how to avoid getting “lost in complexity” in the implementation process. With a focus on implementing the 2030 Agenda from an ocean perspective, it explores the possibility of a developing a related thematic review and raises questions concerning this matter that require in-depth discussion at the 2017 Potsdam Ocean Governance Workshop and beyond.

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1. Background

There is a widespread recognition of the interconnected nature of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.¹ Many of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and 169 targets have the potential to create co-benefits or reinforce each other. At the same time, some goals and their underlying targets also may have conflicting relationships. In such cases taking action towards one goal may require trade-offs or constrain other goals or targets. For example, industrialized agriculture aiming to grow more food might place further strain on water, energy and the marine environment. To be effective, co-benefits and tradeoffs have to be taken into account across all SDGs

¹ United Nations (2015). Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. UNGA Resolution A/RES/70/1. Resolution adopted by the General Assembly on 25 September 2015 70/1

when implementing the 2030 Agenda. However, considerable uncertainty in valuing such interactions, e.g. with regard to time and space or the type of assessment and methodology, make it difficult to generalize such complex relationships or to develop appropriate policy options.

From an ocean perspective, some concern has been raised that implementing the 2030 Agenda has so far largely focused on SDG 14 and its ten underlying targets. The UN Ocean Conference in June 2017 in New York, for example, was almost exclusively dedicated to SDG 14 and its targets. However, underlying synergies and trade-offs with other goals and their individual targets must be addressed in order to achieve the 2030 Agenda. Furthermore, SDG 14 will not be achieved without taking into account the wider sustainable development context. Turning the argument around, implementing the ocean agenda and its core SDG 14 in an integrated manner could serve as an example for how co-benefits with other goals and targets could be achieved.

For example, a strong positive relationship exists between ensuring responsible consumption and production (SDG12) and protecting the oceans.² In 2010, as many as 13 million tons of plastic waste ended up in the world's oceans. Encouraging industry, agriculture, and private households to change their consumption and production could decrease this volume of litter, while also minimizing ocean pollution and protecting fragile ecosystems. In short, the marine litter problem will not be solved until production and consumption stop generating plastic waste. To that end, it will be necessary to close resource cycles, encourage behavioral changes, and improve public awareness – measures that are under the remit of institutions outside the ocean governance framework.

A much more complicated set of relationships exists between SDG 14 and SDG 1 (ending poverty). Healthy, productive and resilient oceans and coasts make it possible to grow economies and decrease poverty. At the same time increased economic activity can harm the environment and create pressure on resources. In this context, blue growth or maritime development strategies need to identify which actors and sectors are leading to negative impacts on the marine environment and who would actually be benefiting from such strategies. In addition, some targets within a goal might be contradictory in how they interact with targets in another goal, while others may be synergistic.

National policy makers across the globe now face the challenge of implementing this indivisible agenda and achieving progress across the economic, social, and environmental dimensions of sustainable development. But achieving the SDGs requires more than just a deeper understanding of how these interlinkages work. New forms of integrated governance, assessment processes, and societal learning processes across sectors are now needed to facilitate a successful SDG implementation and review.

2. Challenges and opportunities in addressing SDG interlinkages

One of the key challenges in implementing the SDGs is to understand and to address their interconnected nature. SDGs cannot be achieved in isolation from each other. Indeed, the complexity of SDG interactions itself makes a strong case for more integrated science. But how can we avoid getting “lost in complexity” in the implementation process? The notion that “everything is connected to everything” could easily translate into “unclear where to start” or “impossible to act” as decision makers begin to grapple with these complex relationships. Policy and civil society actors in the

² Schmidt S, Neumann B, Waweru Y, Durussel C, Unger S, Visbeck M (2017): SDG14 Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development. In: International Council for Science (2017): A Guide to SDG Interactions: from Science to Implementation. International Council for Science, Paris, pp 174-218

implementation process would therefore be well advised to identify key interlinkages and priority action areas. These areas of concern should reflect the varying urgencies of issues and related capacity gaps at the national and regional level.

The interconnected nature of the SDGs is a particular challenge for areas with fragmented decision-making and management systems, as is the case in ocean governance. To address these interlinked issues, new forms of integrated ocean governance systems are needed that work across different sectors and policies, both within SDG 14 and beyond.

2.1 Quantifying synergies and conflicts

In a study by the International Council for Science (ICSU) an international team of scientists developed and applied a seven-point scale to quantify synergies and conflicts between goals and targets in the 2030 Agenda.³ The scale ranges from +3, which applies when progress on one goal or target is inextricably linked to progress on another, to -3, which applies when progress on one goal or target might cancel out progress on another.⁴ A score of 0 indicates a neutral interaction.

With regard to the oceans, the report identified interlinkages with all other SDGs and key interactions being mostly synergistic, i.e. delivering co-benefits when addressing these interlinked goals.⁵ But actions taken under SDG 14 may also result in trade-offs, which requires careful balancing between protection and conservation of coastal and marine ecosystems (SDG 14) and much needed development and securing of coastal livelihoods. On the other hand, a decline in ocean health, productivity and resilience due to increasing human pressures is a major threat to achieving e.g. sufficient nutrition (SDG 2), livelihoods (SDG 1) and economic growth (SDG 8). Achieving SDG 14 thus strongly depends on consideration taken of SDG interlinkages, and on actions taken and progress made under other goals.

In this context it should be noted, however, that synergies and trade-offs are highly context dependent, e.g. with regard to place-specific issues or governance contexts. Such issues are critical for achieving SDGs at the regional, national or local level, and need to be reflected in implementation processes.

To reach the full potential of the 2030 Agenda, policy makers, stakeholders, civil society and business should now come together to identify, discuss and quantify these interactions, understand their consequences, and carefully craft actions that are translated into national and regional implementation plans. This will minimize the risks of trade-offs and of costs that would occur if these remain unaddressed. It will increase the effectiveness of strategies and actions by taking advantage of synergies and co-benefits. Such an effort will also likely increase the acceptance of measures taken where synergistic effects and co-benefits may not be visible and obvious at first glance to the various stakeholders and actors.

A simple and transparent methodology such as the one used in the ICSU study could be applied in a way that it supports dialogue between stakeholder and policy-makers, and facilitates the necessary

³ International Council for Science (2017): A Guide to SDG Interactions: from science to implementation. D.J. Griggs, M. Nilsson, A. Stevance, D. McCollum (eds). ICSU, Paris.

⁴ Nilsson, M., Grigg, D., and Visbeck, M. (2016): Map the interactions between Sustainable Development Goals. *Nature*, 534:320-322.

⁵ Schmidt S, Neumann B, Waweru Y, Durussel C, Unger S, Visbeck M (2017): SDG14 Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development. In: International Council for Science (2017): A Guide to SDG Interactions: from Science to Implementation. International Council for Science, Paris, pp 174-218

learning processes to identify priorities and balance conflicting interests in the implementation of the 2030 Agenda. Such processes could take place at different scales, from local to national, regional and global level and provide an ideal basis for informed and coherent decision making. The framework basically employs expert and other relevant forms of knowledge on key interactions and translates qualitative judgements on how influential a given SDG (or target) is on another SDG (or target) into quantitative scores. The framework has been tested and applied at national scale for Sweden⁶ and in various other studies.⁷

It should be noted that this is just one methodology in an emerging field of study in sustainability research. Another promising concept has been proposed by Singh et al. (2017)⁸ that differentiates relationship based on compatibility (co-benefits, trade-off, neutral), the optional nature of achieving one goal in attaining another, and whether these relationships are context specific.

2.2 A thematic ocean review

At the outset, it might seem that the oceans and marine resources will be protected through achieving SDG 14. However, links to the ocean can be found throughout the whole 2030 Agenda. Indeed, healthy oceans are indispensable for reaching many of the SDGs while at the same time reaching other SDGs will place increasing demands on the marine environment. Achieving the SDGs therefore requires coordinated implementation, follow-up and review that takes into account the co-benefits and trade-offs between the goals. The 2030 Agenda suggests that overarching “thematic reviews of progress on the Sustainable Development Goals, including cross-cutting issues” should be prepared. The meeting of the High-level Political Forum (HLPF) on sustainable development under the auspices of the Economic and Social Council was held in 2017 under the theme “*Eradicating poverty and promoting prosperity in a changing world*” included a review of SDG 14 (together with SDG 1, 2, 3, 5, and 9 as well as 17). For HLPF 2017 a background note called “2017 HLPF Thematic review of SDG 14: Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development” was prepared by the UN⁹ (similar background documents were also put forward for the other SDGs under review at HLPF 2017). This background document for HLPF included a brief initial overview on the status of key SDG 14 targets at the global scale, but fell short of an in-depth analysis of cross-sectoral interlinkages with other goals and targets, that could guide the further implementation process.

Developing in depth thematic reviews on cross-cutting issues would facilitate the implementation of the 2030 Agenda as a package and ensure that trade-offs and synergies are taken into account.¹⁰ To that end, a systematic follow-up and review of the SDGs would require the effective selection of topics for thematic reviews. Acknowledging the fact that the oceans, seas and marine resources have been included in a standalone SDG, the integrated and cross-cutting nature of the oceans for the

⁶ Weitz N, Carlsen H, Nilsson M, Skånberg K (2017) Towards systemic and contextual priority setting for implementing the 2030 Agenda. *Sustain Sci*. doi:10.1007/s11625-017-0470-0

⁷ Nilsson, M., Chisholm, E., Griggs, D., Howden-Chapman, P., McCollum, D., Messerli, P., Neumann, B., Visbeck, M., Stafford-Smith, M.: Mapping interactions in the 2030 Agenda - lessons learned and ways forward. (in progress)

⁸ Singh, G. G., A. M. Cisneros-Montemayor, W. Swartz, W. Cheung, J. A. Guy, T.-A. Kenny, C. J. McOwen, R. Asch, J. L. Geffert, C. C. C. Wabnitz, R. Sumaila, Q. Hanich & Y. Ota (2017) A rapid assessment of co-benefits and trade-offs among Sustainable Development Goals. *Marine Policy*

⁹ <https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/14375SDG14format-revOD.pdf>

¹⁰ Lobos Alva, I., Weigelt, J. (2016): Thematic Reviews in the 2030 Agenda: The Case for a Review of Natural Resources. Brief for Global Sustainable Development Report - 2016 Update.

entire 2030 Agenda would merit a thematic approach for the oceans across all 17 SDGs (see Figure 1).

A thematic review for the ocean would identify priority interlinkages and issues, evaluate current policies, and weigh policy options.¹¹ By offering insights into interlinkages with other SDGs and shedding light on global and regional trends, the review would also provide an evidential basis for the development of cross-cutting policy measures. In that way a thematic review could help to establish the “policy arena” in which actors in ocean governance can act and actually affect change towards sustainability. It could not only facilitate greater integration within the marine and maritime sectors (as provided for by SDG 14) but also provide a knowledge platform that could help ocean issues break out of their “silo” and support urgently needed policy coherence and integration with sectors beyond the marine realm (e.g. with agriculture, transportation, consumption and production, or economic development).



Figure 1: Interlinkages between SDG 14 and other SDGs (Source: Unger et al. 2017)

2.3 Relation to other assessments and state of the ocean reports

A global thematic ocean review would need to be linked coherently to the follow-up and review process under the HLPF and apply a nested approach with other governance levels, most notably the regional and national level. Regional seas conventions and economic organisations already prepare regional ocean assessments that could provide important baseline information for a global thematic review and, conversely, could help to articulate this approach coherently at the regional and national level. Other reports on the state of the marine environment and its resources would provide important sources of information, e.g. the FAO State of the World Fisheries and Aquaculture report. Such a review should be strategic, bringing together relevant actors from different sectors on an equal footing with the aim of increasing cross-sectoral cooperation. Thematic reviews should

¹¹ Unger, S.; Müller, A.; Rochette, J.; Schmidt, S.; Shackeroff, J.; Wright, G. (2017): Achieving the Sustainable Development Goal for the Oceans. IASS Policy Brief 1/2017.

therefore be pioneered as collective learning processes that provide guidance for associated SDG follow-up and review processes.

One has to be aware that the development of a global thematic review would take place in an already existing ocean and sustainability governance arena. Linkages to other relevant processes therefore need to be considered carefully, both in terms of creating synergies and avoiding duplication.

In particular UN Member States have highlighted the potential of the World Ocean Assessment (WOA) to support the further implementation of the 2030 Agenda and SDG 14.¹² In 2004 the United Nations General Assembly set up the “Regular Process for Global Reporting and Assessment of the State of the Marine Environment, including Socioeconomic Aspects”. As a scientific basis for decision-making, the regular process developed the first global integrated assessment of the marine environment, World Ocean Assessment I (WOA I). The second cycle of the Regular process will take place from 2017-2020 and a series of regional workshops took place in autumn 2017 to build capacity, support the development of assessment(s), and facilitate outreach and awareness. In statements on lessons learned from the first cycle of the Regular Process, inter alia from the EU, it was suggested that it should support the follow-up and review of efforts to achieve the Sustainable Development Goal for the Oceans. WOA II could be developed with a focus on the objectives of SDG 14, considering not only its targets but also those goals and targets in the 2030 Agenda which directly affect its achievement. In future, the World Ocean Assessments conducted through the Regular Process could thus become a cornerstone of a global thematic review of the oceans and coasts in support of the 2030 Agenda.

The upcoming IPCC Special Report on the Ocean and Cryosphere in a Changing Climate (SROCC) will play an important role with regard to ocean and climate interactions. At its 43rd Session (Nairobi, Kenya, 11-13 April 2016), the IPCC decided to prepare a special report on climate change and the oceans and the cryosphere. The report will be finalized by September 2019 and will address the following main themes: 1) high mountain areas; 2) Polar regions; 3) sea level rise and implication for low-lying islands, coasts, and communities; 4) changing oceans, marine ecosystems, and dependent communities; 5) extremes, abrupt changes and managing risks. The “Ocean Pathway”¹³ launched by Fiji during COP 23 supports the elaboration of the special report and flags the possibility of a UNFCCC agenda and a work programme item on oceans and climate by 2019.

Despite limited relevance so far for the marine environment, the Intergovernmental Science-Policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services (IPBES) could also be a relevant forum to consider SDG interactions and support any such thematic assessment.

3. Discussion points for the workshop

For the first time, the ocean has been included prominently within a globally agreed overarching sustainability agenda. This presents a great opportunity for future ocean governance, but implementing the 2030 Agenda and the SDGs as an “indivisible whole” is a great challenge for the current institutional and legal framework. Indeed, the sheer number of possible interactions is beyond the capacities of any meaningful implementation process. However, the nature, degree of

¹² See e.g. the Statement by the EU on lessons learned from the first cycle of the Regular Process: http://www.un.org/depts/los/global_reporting/lessons_learned_submission.htm

¹³ <http://sdg.iisd.org/news/ocean-pathway-launched-at-cop-23/>

urgency, and the scope of interactions vary considerably. Therefore, it is first necessary to improve understanding of the possible interactions and to identify priorities. A thematic review for the ocean would provide a crosscutting review of the goals and targets to achieve the 2030 Agenda from an ocean perspective. A rigorous thematic review of implementation from an ocean perspective would not only help to identify and address critical SDG interlinkages and provide needed integrated ocean assessments; it would open new opportunities for collaboration amongst UN Agencies, science and civil society¹⁴ and could serve as a driver for greater coordination and cooperation in ocean governance. Starting off with a round of short introductory presentations, this workshop session will seek to discuss the following questions:

SDG interlinkages

- How to identify and prioritize key interlinkages at national, regional and global level?
- In what way can the assessment of interlinkages help to guide the implementation process?
- How to address different short-term and long-term linkages and consequences of SDG implementation and how to deal with a changing nature of interlinkages under the conditions of global change?
- How to reflect context- and place specific issues in quantifying/evaluating interactions?
- How to deal with interactions that fall in the remit of different governance institutions?
- How to ensure adequate participation of all relevant actors and stakeholders?

Thematic reviews

- Taking into account the lessons learned from the UN Ocean Conference and HLPF in 2017, how could a thematic oceans review support the integrated implementation of the 2030 Agenda?
- How could a thematic review from an ocean perspective help to translate assessments of SDG interlinkages into action oriented measures at the national and regional scale?
- How could a thematic review help to systematically pool our knowledge on SDG interactions?
- How to identify priorities and address complex sustainability challenges falling under the remit of different governance regimes, e.g. land/ocean connections, as part of a thematic review?
- Should we institutionalize such a review in the UN system? Or would it be better placed outside the UN?
- Acknowledging that thematic reviews should be conducted for several key issues, how could a case be made for a thematic review of the oceans?

Recommendations for possible next steps

- How to better reflect SDG interactions from an ocean perspective in the implementation process of the 2030 Agenda and SDG 14 in particular?
- What are possible next steps towards a thematic ocean review?
- How to link to the HLPF, follow-up processes from the UN Ocean Conference (as progressed by the UN Secretary General's Ocean Envoy), the "Ocean Pathway" (as launched during UNFCCC COP 23) or other relevant processes (e.g. the UN "Regular Process").

¹⁴ Lobos Alva, I., Weigelt, J. (2016): Thematic Reviews in the 2030 Agenda: The Case for a Review of Natural Resources. Brief for Global Sustainable Development Report - 2016 Update.

Annex 1 - Interesting preparatory reading

- Unger, S.; Müller, A.; Rochette, J.; Schmidt, S.; Shackeroff, J.; Wright, G. (2017): Achieving the Sustainable Development Goal for the Oceans. IASS Policy Brief 1/2017. <http://www.iass-potsdam.de/de/ergebnisse/publikationen/2017/achieving-sustainable-development-goal-oceans>
- Schmidt S, Neumann B, Waweru Y, Durussel C, Unger S, Visbeck M (2017): SDG14 Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development. In: International Council for Science (2017): A Guide to SDG Interactions: from Science to Implementation. International Council for Science, Paris, pp 174-218, <https://www.icsu.org/publications/a-guide-to-sdg-interactions-from-science-to-implementation>
- Mans Nilsson on „Do we need a common knowledge platform on SDG interactions?“, <http://deliver2030.org/?p=8265>
- OECD (2016), Better Policies for Sustainable Development 2016: A New Framework for Policy Coherence, OECD Publishing, Paris. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1787/9789264256996-en>